GROW FOOD SYSTEM

FREE STARTER GUIDE

The Home Food System Starter Guide

A clear starting point for planning your space, choosing what to grow first, avoiding common early mistakes, and building a home food system with more confidence.

- Decide where to start
- Choose a small first setup
- Pick sensible first crops
- Avoid wasting time, money, and momentum

How to use this guide

The goal is not to plan everything at once. Use this guide to make the next few decisions well, then grow from there.

THE 4-PART ROADMAP

1. **Plan your space** — work from the space, time, and maintenance you actually have.
2. **Choose what to grow first** — start with food you already eat and can realistically keep up with.
3. **Avoid early mistakes** — keep the first version simple enough to learn from.
4. **Expand with confidence** — add more only after the basics are working.

Quick self-check before you begin

- [ ] I know roughly how much sun my starting space gets.
- [ ] I can name 3 to 5 foods I would genuinely like to grow and use.
- [ ] I know how much time I can realistically give this each week.
- [ ] I am willing to start smaller than I think I need to.

01 Plan your space

A good first setup fits your real conditions. Before you plant anything, decide what kind of growing area you can actually maintain.

Ask yourself:

- [ ] Where is the easiest place to check on every day?
- [ ] What area gets the most reliable light?
- [ ] What can I water and maintain without turning this into a chore?
- [ ] Do I need containers, one bed, or a very small test area to start?

SMALL SPACE

Start with containers, herbs, salad leaves, and one or two high-value crops. Keep the setup compact and easy to reach.

BACKYARD OR LARGER PLOT

Begin with one core growing area, not the whole garden. It is easier to expand a working system than rescue an oversized one.

KEEP THIS SIMPLE

Your first win is not scale. It is clarity. Decide on one starting area, one routine, and one simple plan you can stick to for the next month.

02 Choose what to grow first

The best first crops are not the ones that sound impressive. They are the ones you are likely to use, enjoy, and successfully manage.

TYPE	GOOD EARLY OPTIONS	WHY THEY WORK
Quick wins	Leafy greens, herbs, salad leaves	Fast feedback and easy harvesting
Useful staples	Tomatoes, peas, beans, courgettes	High satisfaction if they fit your climate and space
Longer-term value	Berries, rhubarb, perennial herbs	Lower replanting pressure once established

A GOOD FIRST SHORTLIST

- Pick 3 to 5 things only.
- Choose at least one quick win, one useful staple, and one thing you are genuinely excited about.
- Avoid planting too many different crops in the first round.

A simple rule: if you would not be happy to eat it regularly, do not let it take up your first growing space.

03 Avoid common early mistakes

Most early frustration comes from trying to do too much too soon. Keep the first version small, clear, and easy to maintain.

MISTAKE	BETTER MOVE
Trying to build the whole system at once	Start with one small setup and one clear routine.
Buying too many supplies before you have a plan	Decide the space and crops first, then buy only what that first setup needs.
Growing food you do not actually use	Choose crops around your real meals, not around other people's lists.
Ignoring how much time upkeep takes	Choose a pace and size you can realistically manage every week.

REMEMBER

The first version does not need to be beautiful, large, or complete. It needs to work well enough that you keep going.

04 Grow with confidence

Once the basics are working, you can expand with much more confidence. The right time to add more is after the first setup feels stable and understandable.

Expand in this order:

- [ ] Improve what is already working before adding more beds, containers, or crop types.
- [ ] Repeat successful crops or methods rather than starting from zero each time.
- [ ] Add one new layer at a time: another container, another crop type, a simple perennial, or a preservation habit.
- [ ] Keep notes on what gave you the best return in food, confidence, and effort.

WHERE THIS CAN LEAD

- A clearer annual routine.
- A more reliable harvest from the same space.
- Better decisions about what is worth expanding.
- A home food system that becomes easier to manage because it was built in sensible stages.

One approach that brings all of this together over time is the food forest model — a growing system designed to become more self-managing as it matures.

Your first 30-day plan

Use this as a simple working rhythm for the first month. Adjust it to your own climate and season.

WEEK	MAIN FOCUS	KEEP IT SIMPLE
1 WEEK	Walk the space, note light, decide where the first growing area goes.	Choose one workable area only.
2 WEEK	Decide what to grow first and what containers or beds you actually need.	Limit yourself to 3–5 crops.
3 WEEK	Prepare the area, gather compost and soil, label what goes where.	Avoid buying too much at once.
4 WEEK	Plant, water, observe, and write down what is working.	Adjust before expanding.

A USEFUL TARGET

By the end of the first month, you should know what space you are using, what you are growing first, what needs adjusting, and what the next sensible step is.

Starter worksheet

Write your decisions down before you buy or plant anything else. Clarity saves money and prevents drift.

My starting space is:

The foods I want to grow first are:

The maintenance time I can realistically give each week is:

The one thing I am deliberately NOT doing yet is:

My next sensible step this week is:

Grow Food System

Use this guide to start with more clarity, then keep building in stages. Small, well-judged systems beat ambitious but unworkable plans every time.

Check your inbox over the next few days — you'll get short follow-up emails with more practical guidance on getting started.

When you're ready to go deeper, *The Complete Food Forest Guide* takes you through the full system.